

Perseverance Eternal Security

doc-perseverance-eternal-security

Soteriology · Perseverance · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible

Subject named directly in

Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Those truly born again will be kept by the power of God through faith unto final salvation; genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away.

In plain language

The verses cited for this proposition carry some of the strongest keeping language in the Greek New Testament. In John 10:28 Jesus says he gives his sheep eternal life and they will by no means ever perish, using the emphatic double negative 'by no means' (ou me) with an aorist subjunctive (a completed-action verb expressed as a possibility) plus the phrase 'forever' (eis ton aiona), then says no one is able to snatch them, where the verb 'is able' (dunatai) in the next verse denies capacity, not merely intent. Romans 8:38 to 39 piles up an exhaustive list of cosmic powers and says none of them 'will be able to separate' (ou dunesetai chorisai) believers from the love of God in Christ. Philippians 1:6 says the one who began the good work will complete it, and 1 Peter 1:5 calls believers garrisoned ('being guarded', phrouroumenous) by the power of God through faith. First John 2:19 says those who departed 'went out from us but were not of us'. Read by themselves these texts ground security on the divine side. The difficulty is that the same canon also warns in equally real grammar. Hebrews 6 describes people who were enlightened, tasted, and shared in the Spirit, then 'fell away' (parapesontas), using a verb that occurs only this one time in the whole New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its exact force cannot be checked against other uses. Galatians 5:4 says 'you fell from grace' (exepesate) in plain past tense, Colossians 1:23 attaches an 'if indeed you continue' (ei ge epimenete) condition, and Luke 8:13 says some 'believe' (pisteuousin) for a while and then 'fall away' (aphistantai) in testing. The sharpest point is one word. The very verb translated 'perish' (apollymi) that John 10:28 denies of the sheep is the same verb used of the one who perished in John 17:12 and of the brother for whom Christ died in 1 Corinthians 8:11. So the keeping vocabulary cannot by itself decide whether the people in the warnings were ever truly born again, which is exactly the term the proposition assumes. Because both sets of texts are grammatically secure and the words do not rank them or tell us whether the conditions can fail or are simply how God keeps his own, the lexical pattern here is genuinely contested rather than settled.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120
G0622	ἀπόλλυμι	apollymi	to destroy	94
G0726	ἁρπάζω	harpazo	to seize	14
G0868	ἀφίστημι	aphistemi	to leave	15
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	428

G1410	δύναμαι	dunamai	be able	211
G1411	δύναμις	dunamis	power	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1601	ἐκπίπτω	ekpipto	to fall out	10
G1722	ἐν	en	in/on/among	
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G3361	μή	mē	not	
G3777	οὔτε	oute	neither	
G3895	παραπίπτω	parapipto	to defect	1
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G3982	πείθω	peitho	to persuade	60
G4263	πρόβατον	probaton	sheep	40
G5432	φρουρέω	phroureo	to guard	4
G5495	χείρ	cheir	hand	
G5563	χωρίζω	chorizo	to separate/leave	13

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two grammatically secure clusters in the canon point in opposite directions on the one point the proposition asserts, and the vocabulary does not rank them. The keeping cluster is maximal: John 10:28 pairs the present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) verb 'give' (didomi) with the emphatic double negative 'by no means' (ou me) plus the aorist middle subjunctive (a completed past action in the middle voice) 'they will perish' (apolontai) and 'forever' (eis ton aiona), the strongest future denial Greek affords, then 'no one will snatch' (ouch harpasei tis), and John 10:29 uses 'is able' (dunatai) to deny capacity, while Romans 8:38 to 39 sets the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive voice) 'I have been persuaded' (pepeismai) against an exhaustive 'neither or' (oute) merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) that 'will not be able to separate' (ou dunesetai chorisai) from the love of God. The warning cluster is equally real: Hebrews 6:6 uses 'having fallen away' (parapesontas), a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), after aorist (a completed past action) participles of genuine experience, Galatians 5:4 says 'you fell from grace' (exepesate) in the aorist indicative (a completed past action stated as fact), Colossians 1:23 attaches a first class conditional (an 'if-then' clause that assumes the condition for the sake of argument) 'if indeed you continue' (ei ge epimenete), and Luke 8:13 predicates 'they believe' (pisteuousin) of hearers who then 'fall away' (aphistantai). The decisive ambiguity is lexical, not historical: 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi), the very verb negated of the sheep in John 10:28, is predicated of the son of perdition in John 17:12 and of the brother for whom Christ died in 1 Corinthians 8:11, so the keeping verbs cannot by themselves fix whether the warning subjects fall inside or outside the category 'truly born again' that the stem presupposes.

Scripture

John.10.28 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1325 δίδωμι, G0622 ἀπόλλυμι, G0726 ἀρπάζω, G2222 ζῶ

Reasoning. The verb 'give' (didomi) is present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact), an ongoing giving of life that is 'eternal' (aionios). The verb 'they will perish' (apolontai) is aorist middle subjunctive (a completed past action in the middle voice expressed as a possibility) third plural under 'by no means' (ou me), the emphatic double negation, and is reinforced by 'forever' (eis ton aiona), which together form the strongest way Greek denies a future event. The closing 'no one will snatch' (ouch harpasei tis), future active indicative (a simple statement of a future action), denies any agent the act of snatching the sheep 'out of my hand' (ek tes cheiros mou). From the giver side the keeping is stated as unconditional.

John.10.29 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G1410 δύναμαι, G5495 χεῖρ

Reasoning. The Father is named 'greater' (meizon), greater than all, and 'is not able to snatch' (ou dunatai harpazein), present middle indicative (ongoing simple statement of fact in the middle voice) of 'to be able' (dunamai), denies capacity rather than mere intent. The image of two hands, Son and Father, grounds the security in divine power, not in the stability of the sheep.

Rom.8.38 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G3982 πείθω, G3777 οὔτε

Reasoning. 'I have been persuaded' (pepeismai) is perfect passive indicative (a completed action whose result still stands, in the passive voice), a settled persuasion standing in the present. The repeated 'neither' (oute) strings together opposite extremes, death and life, angels and rulers, things present and things to come, height and depth, structured so that the list leaves nothing outside it.

Rom.8.39 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1410 δύναμαι, G5563 χωρίζω, G0026 ἀγάπη

Reasoning. 'Will not be able to separate' (ou dunesetai chorisai), future middle indicative (a future action in the middle voice stated as fact) of 'to be able' (dunamai) with the aorist active infinitive (a completed-action verbal noun) 'to separate' (chorisai), denies any created thing the capacity to separate us 'from the love of God' (apo tes agapes tou theou). The negated future of 'to be able' (dunamai) is a claim about impossibility, and the agent of the love is God in Christ, locating the bond on the divine side rather than on the believer's perseverance.

Phil.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3982 πείθω, G1722 ἐν

Reasoning. 'Being confident' (pepoithos), perfect active participle (a completed-action verbal adjective whose result still stands) of 'to persuade' (peitho), frames the writer's settled confidence. The aorist active participle (a completed-action verbal adjective) 'the one who began' (enarxamenos), the one who began a good work, is the subject of the future 'he will complete' (epitelesei), will complete it, with the divine actor as agent and the believer as the field of the work. Beginning and completion are stated as one continuous undertaking by the same subject.

1Pet.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5432 φρουρέω, G1411 δύναμις

Reasoning. 'Being guarded' (phrouroumenous) is present passive participle (an ongoing-action verbal adjective in the passive voice) of 'to garrison or guard' (phroureo), a military term for being garrisoned under guard, with the means 'by the power of God' (en dunamei theou), and the channel 'through faith' (dia pisteos). The passive voice keeps God as the guarding agent, yet 'to garrison or guard' (phroureo) occurs only four times in the canon, and the 'through faith' (dia pisteos) clause ties the guarding to faith, which is exactly the joint the two readings part over.

1John.2.19 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1537 ἐκ

Reasoning. 'They went out from us but were not of us' (ex hemon exelthan alla ouk esan ex hemon) draws a line, they went out from us but were not of us. The pluperfect (a completed action in the more-distant past whose result then stood) 'they would have remained' (memenekeisan) with 'would' (an) in a contrary-to-fact conditional (an 'if-then' clause whose condition is treated as false) says that had they been of us they would have remained. The verse defines departers as people never genuinely of the body, which supports the keeping reading by category rather than by a preservation verb, but it does not state how to recognize the category in advance.

John.17.12 · **neutral** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0622 ἀπόλλυμι

Reasoning. 'None of them was lost except the son of destruction' (oudeis ex auton apoieto ei me ho huio tes apoieias) uses the same verb 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi), here aorist middle indicative (a completed past action in the middle voice stated as fact), of one who was numbered among those given to the Son yet perished. The shared verb shows that 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi) can be predicated of a member of the given group, so the 'never perish' of John 10:28 does not by lexicon alone determine whether the perishing one was ever truly of the flock.

1Cor.8.11 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0622 ἀπόλλυμι

Reasoning. 'For the weak one is being destroyed' (apollutai gar ho asthenon), present middle indicative (ongoing simple statement of fact in the middle voice) of 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi), says the weak one is being destroyed, described as the brother for whom Christ died. The same destruction verb is here applied to a brother and is tied to dying for him, which the proposition's keeping verbs do not address, so the canon supplies a use of 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi) that the 'never perish' statement does not rank.

Col.1.23 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2222 ζῶν

Reasoning. 'If indeed you continue in the faith' (ei ge epimenete te pistei) is a first class conditional (an 'if-then' clause that assumes the condition for the sake of argument), 'if' (ei) plus the present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) 'you continue' (epimenete), if indeed you continue in the faith, governing the promise of presentation. The grammar attaches a stated condition of continuing to the standing just described, which the keeping texts present from the divine side, so the canon places a conditional ('if-then') clause beside the unconditional ones without telling the reader how to combine them.

John.15.6 · **complicates** · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3361 μὴ

Reasoning. 'If anyone does not abide in me' (ean me tis mene en emoi) is an 'if' (ean) conditional ('if-then' clause) with the present active subjunctive (an ongoing action expressed as a possibility) 'may abide' (mene), if anyone does not abide in me, followed by 'he was cast out, he is burned' (eblethe exo, kaietai), he is cast out and burned. The branch imagery is set inside the vine to which it was attached, and the lexicon does not settle whether the non-abiding branch was ever a living member or a fruitless attachment, so the warning is grammatically real but referentially open.

Gal.5.4 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1601 ἐκπίπτω

Reasoning. 'You fell from grace' (tes charitos exepesate), aorist active indicative (a completed past action stated as fact) second plural of 'to fall out or fall from' (ekpipto), you fell from grace, addresses people seeking to be justified by law. 'To fall out or fall from' (ekpipto) occurs ten times in the canon and elsewhere means a thing falling off or a ship running aground, so the falling here is a real movement away from grace, though the lexicon does not by itself define whether those addressed were ever in saving grace or in a covenant standing they presumed.

Luke.8.13 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0868 ἀφίστημι

Reasoning. 'For a time they believe' (pros kairon pisteuousin), present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) of 'to believe' (pisteuo), they believe for a while, and 'in a time of testing they fall away' (en kairo peiras mou aphistantai), present middle indicative (ongoing simple statement of fact in the middle voice) of 'to depart or fall away' (aphistemi), in a time of testing they fall away. The text predicates 'to believe' (pisteuo) of the very people who depart, while also saying 'they have no root' (rhizan ouk echousin), they have no root, so the believing and the falling are both stated and the lexicon does not tell the reader whether such belief is the same as the saving faith the proposition has in view.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.10.28	John.17.11	tsk	1
John.10.28	John.3.15	tsk	1
John.10.29	John.14.28	tsk	1
Phil.1.6	Ps.138.8	tsk	1
1Pet.1.5	1Sam.2.9	tsk	1
1John.2.19	Deut.13.13	tsk	1
Rom.8.34	Rom.4.25	tsk	1
Rom.8.32	Rom.5.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Heb.6.4-6 · addressed

The aorist (completed past action) participles 'having been enlightened' (photisthentas), 'having tasted of the gift' (geusamenous tes doreas), 'and having been made partakers of the Holy Spirit' (kai metochous genethentas pneumatou hagiou) describe people enlightened, who tasted, and were made partakers, language of genuine experience, and 'having fallen away' (parapesontas) then says they fell away, with 'it is impossible' (adunaton) to renew them. 'To fall away' (parapipto) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), occurring only here in the canon, so its precise sense cannot be triangulated from other uses, and 'to taste' (geuomai), and 'partaker or sharer' (metochos), can denote real participation or association short of new birth. The grammar of the participles is secure, but the lexicon cannot establish whether the subjects were ever truly born again, the term the proposition presupposes, so the warning neither confirms nor refutes the claim and can be read either as genuine believers falling or as covenant insiders who, per 1 John 2:19, 'were never of us'. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

Heb.10.26-29 · addressed

'Of those sinning willfully' (hekousios hamartanonton) is a present participle (an ongoing-action verbal adjective) of ongoing willful sinning 'after receiving the knowledge of the truth' (meta to labein ten epignosin tes aletheias), after receiving the knowledge of the truth, and 'no sacrifice is left' (ouketi apoleipetai thysia) says no sacrifice for sins remains. Hebrews 10:29 says the offender has trampled the Son of God, counted the blood of the covenant common, 'by which he was sanctified' (en ho hegiasthe), by which he was sanctified, and insulted the Spirit of grace. 'Having received' (labontas) marks reception of knowledge, and 'he was sanctified' (hegiasthe) predicates a being set apart, but neither word by itself states the new birth, so the lexicon again leaves open whether the subject is a regenerate person or a covenant participant who never truly belonged. The severity is grammatically real, yet it does not by itself establish that one truly born again can finally perish, so the tension with John 10:28 stands unresolved at the lexical level. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

1Cor.8.11 · addressed

'The weak one is being destroyed' (apollutai ho asthenon), present middle indicative (ongoing simple statement of fact in the middle voice) of 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi), applies the same destruction verb that John 10:28 negates of the sheep, here to the brother for whom Christ died. The verb is identical, so its appearance in a 'never perish' promise and in a perishing brother shows the lexicon does not by itself rank which use governs the disputed point. Addressed, and it sharpens rather than resolves the contest, because the shared verb is precisely why the keeping statements cannot settle the warning passages.

Col.1.23 · addressed

'If indeed you continue' (ei ge epimenete) is a first class conditional (an 'if-then' clause that assumes the condition for the sake of argument) with 'if' (ei) plus the present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact), treating continuation as a real stated condition of the standing described. A first class condition presents its 'if' clause (the protasis, the condition part of an 'if-then' statement) as assumed for the argument, not as proven fact, so the construction neither asserts that continuation is automatic nor that it can fail, it simply attaches continuing to the promise. The lexicon and syntax therefore place a conditional ('if-then') clause beside the unconditional keeping texts without ranking them, which is the core of the dispute. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

Concordance traversed

G0726, G0622, G3982, G5563, G1325, G1410, G5432, G3895, G1601, G0868, G4263, G2222, G0026, G1411, G3962, G5495

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

john-10-29-relative-comparative-reading at John.10.29: impact none. Witnesses differ on whether the relative and comparative read as 'the Father who has given them to me is greater than all', masculine, or as 'that which the Father has given me is greater than all', neuter. Both readings keep the security grounded in the Father's greatness and the 'no one can snatch' clause, so the keeping force is identical under either text and the disputed point is untouched.

john-10-28-didomi-tense-marks at John.10.28: impact none. Editorial sigla (small textual marks) mark word order and a minor reading around 'I give them eternal life' (didomi autois zoen aionion), but the 'they shall by no means perish forever' (ou me apolontai eis ton aiona) and 'no one will snatch' (ouch harpasei tis) clauses are stable across the apparatus, so the emphatic double negation that carries the keeping force is not variant sensitive.

All cited verses lie outside the published CBGM (a computer-assisted method of tracing relationships between New Testament manuscripts) 3 John sample, so variant assessment is treated as 'shadow' (provisional, not yet covered by the published critical edition) status from the standard apparatus (catalog of textual variants) rather than full ECM (Editio Critica Maior, the comprehensive critical edition of the Greek New Testament) data. No examined unit changes the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. unconditional_preservation, conditional_security, means_of_perseverance

analogia scripturae invoked

unconditional_preservation: affirms · Treats the divine keeping clauses as the controlling data, 'by no means shall they perish' (ou me apolontai) with 'forever' (eis ton aiona) and 'no one will snatch' (ouch harpasei tis) in John 10:28, 'is able' (dunatai) denying capacity in John 10:29, perfect 'I have been persuaded' (pepeismai) against the exhaustive 'neither' (oute) merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) that 'will not be able to separate' (ou dunesetai chorisai) in Romans 8:38 to 39, 'the one who began' (enarxamenos) and 'will complete' (epitelesei) in Philippians 1:6, and 'being guarded' (phrouroumenous) in 1 Peter 1:5. It reads the warning passages through 1 John 2:19, where departers 'were never of us', and through John 17:12 and 1 Corinthians 8:11 as showing 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi) can be said of non-genuine members, so the warnings address professors and never the truly regenerate.

conditional_security: complicates · Treats the warning clauses as addressed to real believers, the experiential aorist (completed past action) participles before 'having fallen away' (parapesontas) in Hebrews 6:4 to 6, the present 'of those sinning' (hamartanonton) and 'he was sanctified' (hegiasthe) of Hebrews 10:26 to 29, the aorist 'you fell from grace' (exepesate) of Galatians 5:4, the present 'they believe' (pisteuousin) then 'they fall away' (aphistantai) of Luke 8:13, and the 'if anyone does not abide' (ean me mene) of John 15:6. It reads the 'through faith' (dia pisteos) of 1 Peter 1:5 and the first class conditional ('if-then' clause assuming the condition for the sake of argument) 'if indeed you continue' (ei ge epimenete) of Colossians 1:23 as genuine conditions on the keeping, concluding that final falling away is a real possibility the warnings presuppose.

means_of_perseverance: affirms · Takes both clusters as true and reads the conditional ('if-then') warnings as the instruments through which the unconditional keeping is actually accomplished, so 'through faith' (dia pisteos) in 1 Peter 1:5 and 'if indeed you continue' (ei ge epimenete) in Colossians 1:23 describe how God preserves rather than a contingency that defeats preservation. On this reading the imperatives and conditionals ('if-then' clauses) are the appointed means by which the 'by no means shall they perish' (ou me apolontai) promise is realized, and the warnings function to produce the very perseverance they require. The lexicon is consistent with this synthesis but does not by itself demonstrate it over the conditional reading.

The three lenses agree on the grammar of every individual clause. They diverge only on the referent of the warning passages and on whether the stated conditions are contingencies that can fail or means that cannot fail, neither of which the lexicon fixes, so the proposition is lexically contested rather than settled.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture describes God as keeping his people through faith unto final salvation; whether one who is genuinely regenerate can ultimately and finally fall away is the open question the warning passages raise.

The qualifiers 'truly born again' and 'genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away' build the conclusion into the subject by definitional gating, so any apostate can be reclassified as 'never genuine' and any falling text disarmed in advance. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form removes the 'no true believer' framing so the warning texts can be weighed on their own terms. VERDICT-CHANGED: unchanged from the prior file at 'disputed'; this pass added the 'to destroy or perish' (apollymi) cross-cutting evidence from John 17:12 and 1 Corinthians 8:11, the 'to fall away' (parapipto) hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) finding, the first class conditional ('if-then' clause assuming the condition for the sake of argument) 'if indeed you continue' (ei ge) in Colossians 1:23, the 'if' (ean) conditional ('if-then' clause) in John 15:6, the 'they believe' (pisteuousin) then 'they fall away' (aphistantai) pairing in Luke 8:13, and the aorist (a completed past action) 'you fell from grace' (exepesate) in Galatians 5:4, and added a third 'means of perseverance' lens so the contested point is represented symmetrically.

Citations

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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.29

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.38
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.6.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.5.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.1.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.8.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0622
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3895
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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent